

ZTA Grading Guide

How to grade each team's solution and place it at a level — **Associate**, **Professional** or **Expert**. Rubric, the expected answer at each level, and a score + feedback sheet per use case. The reference answers live in the **ZTA Design Clinic Solution Guide**. **Do not show participants.**

How scoring works. Each use case = **100 points** (Mapping 40 / Products 30 / Diagram 30). Grade against the reference answer (Solution Guide), decide a level per criterion, assign points, then total → overall level. Award partial credit generously; reward Cisco differentiators.

The three levels

Associate 60–74

Foundational: identifies the right general Cisco products and meets the basic requirement, but light on *how* and *why*.

Professional 75–89

Solid, correct design: pains mapped to the right products with a clear how & why and a Cisco differentiator; enforcement points shown.

Expert 90–100

Comprehensive & differentiated: every pain/requirement mapped precisely, multiple differentiators, flows traced end-to-end.

Below Associate = **Developing (< 60)**: incomplete or largely incorrect.

How to grade

1. Read the team's three answer areas against the reference answer for the use case (see the Solution Guide).
2. For each criterion pick a **level** (Associate / Professional / Expert) using the rubric and assign **points** in that band.
3. Total to a **/100** score → the team's **level** for that use case.
4. Write **feedback**: one strength and one concrete improvement; name products.
5. The team's **overall level** = average of submitted use cases (required 1–3; bonus can raise it).

Rubric — criteria × level

CRITERION	MAX	ASSOCIATE	PROFESSIONAL	EXPERT
Pain-point → product mapping	40	20–27 Maps the main pain points to broadly correct products; some gaps or generic choices.	28–34 Maps all pain points to the correct Cisco products, each with a clear reason.	35–40 Every pain mapped precisely to the optimal product with strong justification; no gaps.

CRITERION	MAX	ASSOCIATE	PROFESSIONAL	EXPERT
Products — how & why / differentiators	30	15–20 Names products; explains “how” only partially; few or no differentiators.	21–26 Correct “how” for each product and a real “why”; at least one Cisco differentiator.	27–30 Precise “how” + compelling “why” for every product; multiple Cisco differentiators vs competitors.
Diagram & overall solution	30	15–20 Diagram present and legible; labels groups; enforcement points partial or unclear.	21–26 Labels groups, marks enforcement points; solution coherent and meets the requirements.	27–30 Traces flow(s) end-to-end with policy/matrix detail; considers integration/edge cases; within budget.

Overall level by score

LEVEL	SCORE	MEANING
DEVELOPING	< 60	Incomplete or largely incorrect — missing core products or misunderstands the requirement.
ASSOCIATE	60–74	Foundational: right general products, meets the basic requirement; light on how/why.
PROFESSIONAL	75–89	Solid, correct design: pains mapped with clear how/why and a Cisco differentiator; enforcement points shown.
EXPERT	90–100	Comprehensive & differentiated: every pain/requirement mapped precisely, multiple differentiators, flows traced end-to-end.

Use Case 1 — Managed Environment — Segmentation

Required

100 pts

Segment campus & branch wired/wireless clients into groups (Employees, IOT, deskagents, Guest) and control what each can reach. Pains: VLAN/subnet complexity, labour-intensive profiling, failing PCI, PCs behind on AV/OS, no budget for more firewalls.

Expected answer by level

LEVEL	WHAT A SOLUTION AT THIS LEVEL CONTAINS
ASSOCIATE	Chooses Cisco ISE and SGTs over VLANs/subnets and assigns the four groups (Employees, IOT, deskagents, Guest). Shows the basic intent to restrict IoT and Guest. Light on how the SGT matrix is built; may omit ISE Posture (AV/OS) or the PCI L7 nuance.
PROFESSIONAL	Maps every pain to the right product: ISE profiling (onboarding), SGTs/SGACL enforced on the existing switches (no new firewalls), ISE Posture for AV/OS remediation, and FTD/FW inserted only where L7 is needed for PCI. Defines correct SGT-matrix rules (IoT → DC+Internet only; Guest → Internet only; Mac-mini → on-prem DC only) and cites a Cisco differentiator (SGACL more efficient / topology-independent). Diagram marks enforcement points.
EXPERT	All of Professional, plus an end-to-end story: pxGrid / Rapid Threat Containment , Cisco Secure Workload App Dependency Mapping for DC app segmentation, dynamic vs static SGT assignment and ISE cloud-AI profiling , and integration across switches/routers/FTD/SD-WAN. Diagram traces at least one flow end-to-end (e.g. IoT → DC permit, IoT → Employees deny) and inserts FTD only where L7/PCI requires it. Clearly argues why Cisco (end-to-end SGT, RFC8600 pxGrid) beats competitors.

Score & level

CRITERION	LEVEL (CIRCLE ONE)	POINTS
Pain → product mapping	☐ A ☐ P ☐ E	/ 40
Products — how & why	☐ A ☐ P ☐ E	/ 30
Diagram & overall solution	☐ A ☐ P ☐ E	/ 30
Total & level	☐ Developing ☐ Associate ☐ Professional ☐ Expert	/ 100

Feedback

✓ What the team did well

▲ Where they can improve

Use Case 2 — Remote Workers — Zero Trust Access

Required

100 pts

SASE for remote workers & branches. Requirements: ZTNA for modern apps (VPN only for legacy), block gambling/gaming, contractors clientless RDP, minimal sign-ons, SASE branches. Pains: over-permissive VPN, manual daily VPN, too many sign-ons, kill passwords, Okta too costly, reduce branch cost.

Expected answer by level

LEVEL	WHAT A SOLUTION AT THIS LEVEL CONTAINS
ASSOCIATE	Recognizes ZTNA over full VPN and proposes Cisco Secure Access with the Secure Client ZTA module ; mentions SSO and blocking gambling/gaming. Light on how per-app tunnels, Duo Passport, passwordless, or SASE integration actually work.
PROFESSIONAL	Maps pains correctly: ZTA module (per-app, least-privilege) for modern apps with full VPN kept only for legacy; SWG to block gambling/gaming; browser-only clientless access for contractors; Duo Passport SSO + advanced passwordless ; Duo Directory to replace costly Okta; SD-WAN into Secure Access for SASE. Explains why ZTNA beats full VPN.
EXPERT	All of Professional with the full Secure Access story and Cisco-unique points: Private Resources proxy (publish apps to VPN/ZTA/browser), VPNaaS mapping VPN traffic to SGTs for segmentation (unique to Cisco), Unified Policy for public+private resources, and SD-WAN → Secure Access via IPsec + Direct Internet Access . Diagram shows the SSE enforcement plane and per-user paths (employee/contractor/guest) with identity via Duo. Argues why Duo Passport/passwordless and Cisco SASE win over Okta/competitors.

Score & level

CRITERION	LEVEL (CIRCLE ONE)	POINTS
Pain → product mapping	☐ A ☐ P ☐ E	/ 40
Products — how & why	☐ A ☐ P ☐ E	/ 30
Diagram & overall solution	☐ A ☐ P ☐ E	/ 30
Total & level	☐ Developing ☐ Associate ☐ Professional ☐ Expert	/ 100

Feedback

✓ What the team did well

▲ Where they can improve

Use Case 3 — AI Access and Agent Controls

Required

100 pts

Report and guardrail AI usage from Use Case 2. Requirements: fine-grained tool control, corporate ChatGPT tenant only, control Claude Desktop agents, govern MCP servers (Claude Code). Pains: shadow AI, unknown/over-privileged MCP servers, personal ChatGPT credentials, risky model downloads.

Expected answer by level

LEVEL	WHAT A SOLUTION AT THIS LEVEL CONTAINS
ASSOCIATE	Understands the shadow-AI risk and proposes Secure Access AI Access for visibility/control; mentions restricting ChatGPT to the corporate tenant. Light on MCP-server governance, agent registration, or model inspection.
PROFESSIONAL	Maps pains: Secure Access AI Access (discover/control), AI Gateway to register/manage allowed MCP servers, tenant controls to force the corporate ChatGPT tenant and block personal logins, and semantic inspection to block risky models. Adds Duo IdP for fine-grained authorization and control of Claude Desktop agents.
EXPERT	All of Professional plus agentic depth: Duo IdP agent registration (DCR) governing what registered desktop agents and MCP integrations (Claude Code) may do, DLP via Secure Access + Cisco AI Defense to stop sensitive-data exposure across endpoint/cloud/web, and a clear per-identity fine-grained policy model. Argues why Cisco's AI Gateway + Duo integration is easier and more complete than IdP-only competitors.

Score & level

CRITERION	LEVEL (CIRCLE ONE)	POINTS
Pain → product mapping	☐ A ☐ P ☐ E	/ 40
Products — how & why	☐ A ☐ P ☐ E	/ 30
Diagram & overall solution	☐ A ☐ P ☐ E	/ 30
Total & level	☐ Developing ☐ Associate ☐ Professional ☐ Expert	/ 100

Feedback

✓ What the team did well

▲ Where they can improve

Use Case 4 — Merger & Acquisition — Extend Segmentation

Bonus

100 pts

Integrate a ~100-staff acquisition fast. Remote site has Cisco FTD (Internet edge + AI-cluster segmenting); acquired co uses Okta. Requirements: extend TrustSec segmentation, only selected users reach Site 9951. Pains: how to extend segmentation, don't want to onboard 100 users, minimize auth disruption, breached/passwords.

Expected answer by level

LEVEL	WHAT A SOLUTION AT THIS LEVEL CONTAINS
ASSOCIATE	Proposes extending TrustSec/SGTs to the acquired site and using Duo for the acquired users; basic idea to restrict Site 9951. Light on inline SGT tagging over the S2S VPN, SCIM import, or SSO routing.
PROFESSIONAL	Maps pains: inline SGT tagging on the remote FTD over a site-to-site VPN to extend segmentation from HQ; source/destination SGTs in the FTD policy to restrict Site 9951 to selected users; Duo Directory + SCIM import from Okta (no bulk corporate-directory onboarding); Duo SSO routing so Okta keeps working during transition; Duo passwordless for the breached users.
EXPERT	All of Professional plus SCC pushing SGT policy into SD-WAN (match source branch SGT to destination acquisition FTD), a clean migration path off Okta, and the Cisco differentiators of inline SGT tagging + Duo's easy multi-IdP integration. Diagram shows the S2S tunnel, extended SGTs, the restricted Site 9951 flow, and Duo directory/SSO federation.

Score & level

CRITERION	LEVEL (CIRCLE ONE)	POINTS
Pain → product mapping	☐ A ☐ P ☐ E	/ 40
Products — how & why	☐ A ☐ P ☐ E	/ 30
Diagram & overall solution	☐ A ☐ P ☐ E	/ 30
Total & level	☐ Developing ☐ Associate ☐ Professional ☐ Expert	/ 100

Feedback

✓ What the team did well

▲ Where they can improve

Use Case 5 — Zero Trust across Multicloud Data Center

Bonus

100 pts

Application sprawl across on-prem/AWS/Azure; discover apps (incl. Kubernetes), minimize blast radius, app run-time protection. Requirements: limited budget/native features/virtual appliances, end-to-end segmentation, minimize complexity. Pains: no app visibility, no segmentation plan, K8s latency/visibility, can't patch IoT, too many disparate consoles.

Expected answer by level

LEVEL	WHAT A SOLUTION AT THIS LEVEL CONTAINS
ASSOCIATE	Proposes Cisco Secure Workload to discover and segment applications across on-prem/AWS/Azure and mentions minimizing blast radius. Light on Kubernetes runtime, auto-baseline policy, or unified management.
PROFESSIONAL	Maps pains: Secure Workload App Dependency Mapping for visibility and auto-baseline microsegmentation (discover → validate → enforce); Isovalent (Cilium/eBPF, Tetragon) for Kubernetes observability and runtime protection; Cisco Cloud Control (SCC) to unify the many management interfaces; leverages native cloud features and FTDv virtual appliances for budget.
EXPERT	All of Professional plus the end-to-end policy story: ISE common policy sharing identity/SGT context via pxGrid to Secure Workload and FTD; CSW ↔ FTDv policy sync ; kernel-level protection via eBPF as the runtime differentiator; and a coherent multicloud enforcement design that minimizes complexity and blast radius. Argues why Cisco's CSW+FTD+Isovalent integration beats native-only or point tools.

Score & level

CRITERION	LEVEL (CIRCLE ONE)	POINTS
Pain → product mapping	☐ A ☐ P ☐ E	/ 40
Products — how & why	☐ A ☐ P ☐ E	/ 30
Diagram & overall solution	☐ A ☐ P ☐ E	/ 30
Total & level	☐ Developing ☐ Associate ☐ Professional ☐ Expert	/ 100

Feedback

✓ What the team did well

▲ Where they can improve

Team summary

USE CASE	TRACK	SCORE /100	LEVEL
UC1 — Managed Environment — Segmentation	Required		☐ A ☐ P ☐ E
UC2 — Remote Workers — Zero Trust Access	Required		☐ A ☐ P ☐ E
UC3 — AI Access and Agent Controls	Required		☐ A ☐ P ☐ E
UC4 — Merger & Acquisition — Extend Segmentation	Bonus		☐ A ☐ P ☐ E
UC5 — Zero Trust across Multicloud Data Center	Bonus		☐ A ☐ P ☐ E
Overall	Required 1–3 (+ bonus)	 avg	☐ Developing ☐ Associate ☐ Professional ☐ Expert

Overall feedback

✓ What the team did well

▲ Where they can improve

Proctor: · Team: · Date: